At 11 pm, the Trivandrum-Madras Rajdhani Express pulled into the Ernakulam station. We were made to board a first class compartment in which other passengers were not allowed. Accompanying us were M L Sharma, P M Nair and a few others, including Thiagarajan, a superintendent of CBI who was also in charge of the bureau's Cochin office. A pleasant man in his early 50s, Thiagarajan spoke in Tamil. Deposing in the Rajiv Gandhi assassination case, years later, he would later admit that he omitted a detail from the statement of one of the accused, Perarivalan.

I could not sleep through the journey. I asked Dhankar why we were taken to Madras, and whether more investigation was needed. I was under the impression that I had proved my innocence to the CBI. Dhankar did not reply to any of my questions.

'Be calm, sleep well,' he said.

STRIKING THE FRENCH DEAL

'We have much more than fifty fine engineers.'

Uncertainty stared in the face of ISRO after Vikram Sarabhai's death. The government appointed the then electronics commission chairman M G K Menon to the post of ISRO chairman, as an ad hoc measure. Menon was a gentleman, but Sarabhai's shoes were too big for him. A few months later, however, ISRO got another visionary and a natural leader, Satish Dhawan at the helm. Dhawan was to take forward Sarabhai's agenda, and become one of the three great chairmen India's space programme had. The third was to be U R Rao, who succeeded Dhawan. ISRO, thereafter, never had a chairman of such calibre.

The French deal was the first major project Dhawan inherited from Sarabhai, and brought to fruition. As the person who initiated the talks with SEP, I remained ISRO's prime representative for the project. With SEP keen on only selling an engine, and I keen on a collaboration, there appeared to